



FROM CHAOS TO CLARITY

HOW I CLEANED UP MY MONEY MESS

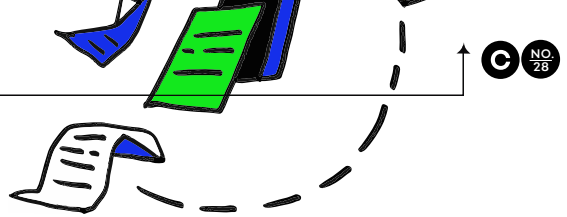
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WRITTEN BY N. Charytan

LIKE MANY OF US, I HAD A DESIRE AND PASSION to make shlichus my life, but no background in managing money. I grew up in Long Island, New York, where my parents, Rabbi Tuvia and Chaya Teldon, have been shluchim for over 40 years. My wife and I moved there on shlichus 17 years ago and took over my parents' Chabad center, a fully operating mosad. As the years passed, though we were accomplishing great things in our shlichus, I resorted to borrowing money as a way to keep afloat.

It happened gradually, and at first I assumed it was the natural, common way to go about shlichus. If debts were due, I eventually paid them off, usually by acquiring another loan from a friend, relative, or other timely savior. As time passed, this unfortunately became the norm for me. I spent an enormous amount of time trying to keep up with credit cards, collection letters, and constantly running from one person to the next trying to borrow even more funds to cover yet another urgent debt. What I thought was an inevitable situation was slowly spiraling into a dangerous cycle.

As time moved on, my money issues took me to a very dark place. Foreclosure was an evident reality, and checks and overdraft fees were merely delay tactics when it came to paying the bills. I felt like I had borrowed money from everyone I knew, and it wasn't a good feel-



ing. The thoughts that kept me constant company were depressing, unproductive, and even harmful to my shlichus. I had hired many well known shlichus fundraising professionals, attended money- and time-management sessions, but nothing was working for me. Not because they had nothing of value to offer. It was simply because I wasn't ready to start doing things differently. I dealt with my situations by procrastinating and avoiding them.

It took me a long time to realize that I was the one who had to implement change. I was desperate—I had nothing more to lose—and I was also frightened. At this point, I considered reaching out for help within my community. Though I knew that a shliach must tread very carefully when it comes to sharing sensitive information with baalei batim, I was lucky to have a few baalei batim I really trusted. They were not necessarily big donors, but they had business experience and valued Chabad's work and vision. Still, I feared I would be ridiculed or cast away as a hopeless case. I worried that if I shared the situation with them and they found out how bad it was, they would drop me and Chabad, right then and there.

Despite my concerns, in 5771 I scheduled a meeting with three of these close baalei batim. I poured out my heart and told them everything. When they asked how large my debt was, I realized I didn't even know myself.

I mentioned a six-digit figure, only later to discover that it was actually more than double that amount! Similarly, when asked about my monthly budget, my estimate was significantly less than the true numbers. Clearly, the situation was much worse than I had even imagined.

I was very surprised at how much these baalei batim were willing to help me out. Though they were probably shocked at the financial mess we were in, they showed respect and offered practical assistance. They saw I genuinely wanted to improve, and provided me with valuable support. They gave me the tools and the motivation I needed to get out of the rut I was in. When sharing such sensitive and personal information, it can be difficult to know who to choose as confidantes. I am very grateful that Hashem sent me the right people at the right time.

Usually, living the way I had been leads to a huge chilul Hashem. Whether in the national press or even just amongst the local baalei batim, the damage to me, my family, and the Rebbe's name could have been irreparable. "I didn't know better" would have been a poor excuse. I thank Hashem that it didn't get there.

I was introduced to the world of budgeting, and began the arduous task of organizing my finances, both personal and those of Chabad. The wife of one of these baalei batim is a bookkeeper. She tackled the monumental job of sifting through piles of paperwork just to get me to the point where I knew the numbers. She literally paused all my spending and made sure every penny was accounted for—I even gave her control of the checkbooks! She

began coming in weekly, and eventually we organized my debts and created attainable goals. These included prioritizing urgent debts and expenses, making phone calls for various financial arrangements, managing monthly payments, and meeting fundraising goals.

I finally learned what funds I needed to sustain my family and shlichus. This was a crucial step in gaining the clarity I needed to move forward to a better place. I realized that my monthly budget was more than I had estimated, and I was encouraged to assign a decent number for my salary (even though I am the one who needs to fundraise for it!). I continued to be accountable to these baalei batim through regular, scheduled follow-up meetings. One of them took me under his wing and guided me through my numerous money-related questions. Reporting back to the group forced me to keep track of things and motivated me to produce. At this point, the mindset of financial organization was still new to me, and getting this type of support was essential.

The process of reaching a healthy financial place took many years, and is still ongoing. At first, we aimed to consolidate and juggle the debts without getting further into debt. We categorized them according to their urgency, so it was clear what needed to be taken care of immediately, what could be divided into regular, scheduled payments, and what could wait until later. I had to overcome my embarrassment and be truly honest with people. I had to tell my creditors where I was holding and request time extensions so I could balance my expenses. Slowly but surely I recovered, and even went so far as to reach out to vendors and employees from many years prior, so that I could repay them. They were blown away and so touched by the gesture. I feel so blessed that I was able to achieve this milestone, baruch Hashem.

I don't necessarily raise more money now, but I have a plan and know exactly where the money is going. Just having the monthly expenses clearly outlined has saved me thousands of dollars a year in overdraft fees. Of course, I also don't waste precious time running around to find loans to cover a last-minute overdue payment, as was common in my previous chaotic state of affairs. I don't use credit cards (at one point I tried using them again and slipped, so I realize they don't work for me), and am a much calmer and happier person.

Looking back, I realize there are many aspects of my life that have changed over the years. Here are some lessons I've learned, and some suggestions I hope can be helpful to fellow shluchim with financial struggles.

1

REMEMBER WHO'S IN CHARGE

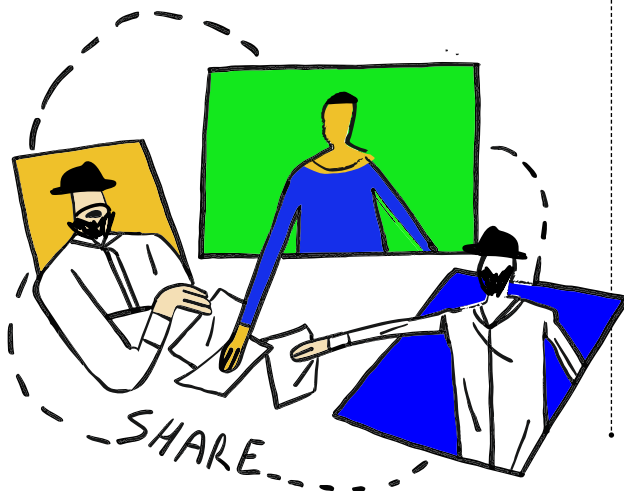
I had to internalize what I was constantly teaching my community: Hashem is present in our mundane lives—even in my finances. Hashem can handle a lot, so let us daven for *all* of our needs with clarity. In addition, Hashem is the One Who plans my every dollar, and no person can take that away. Similarly, no one can be blamed for my lack of financial stability. Accepting this reality was a big part of my taking ownership of my life, and becoming more productive by focusing on the matters I knew were in my court.

2

HAVE A STRONG SUPPORT SYSTEM

I realized how important it was for me to share these life struggles with a mashpia and with friends. Shlichus often entails sitting in an office for many hours alone, and the thoughts that swirl around in your own brain can be disruptive, discouraging, or depressing. Hashing things out with someone outside of your situation brings huge benefits.

At first, I hired fellow shluchim to consult with regarding shlichus-related issues. Eventually, I found a new coach who I connected with well and who helps me tremendously until this day. I also began visiting a therapist regularly, who guided me in my personal life and helped improve my mental and emotional wellbeing. With their assistance, I am now able to see things from a different perspective and can make better decisions. There do exist other shluchim who have been through the same issues as you! You are not alone in your struggle, no matter how crazy it seems. Be open to finding someone to discuss your situation with, and share your goals so you maintain accountability. While seeking professional help has its place and may even be essential to some, I suggest starting off by simply calling a seasoned fellow shliach and taking it from there.



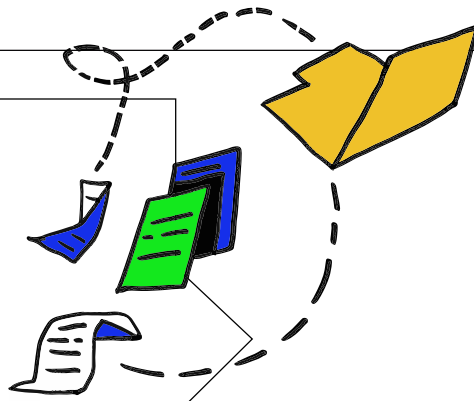
3

CONSIDER WHAT THE REBBE WANTS OF YOU NOW

Success looks different for every shliach. I realized that comparing myself to others was harming my shlichus. It is important to redefine your vision of success on shlichus by thinking about what the Rebbe would want from you in your personal situation. Like every shliach, I have my qualities and my flaws, and I need to focus on the areas of my shlichus that actually make a difference to other Jews in a real way, and allow me to fully utilize my talents. I learned, through honest conversations with friends and fellow shluchim, how to delegate or even drop a program in my shlichus altogether, if I realized it was harming my ability to be a committed, joyous shliach. For me this meant more focus on touching neshamos through personal relationships, chavrusas, Torah classes, and shul programs. With the guidance of my support system I was able to focus on accomplishing my shlichus with renewed clarity and chayus.

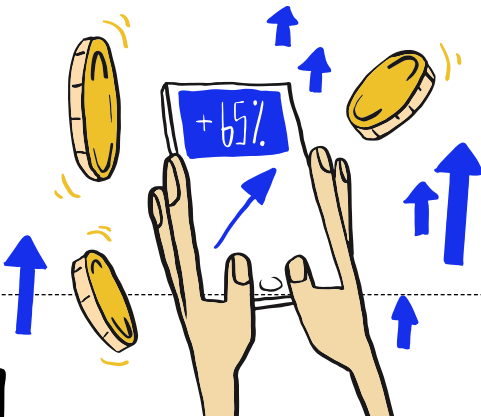
5 HOLD YOURSELF ACCOUNTABLE

I have a proper board to whom I am financially accountable. They understand the reality of my daily expenses, and what it takes to keep Chabad financially afloat. We meet regularly and I make sure to attach due dates to my budgeting and fundraising tasks so that I feel urged to get them done. An additional benefit to this has been that these board members have each grown in their connection to Yiddishkeit and Chabad in various ways as a result of their involvement.



4 LEARN HOW TO PROPERLY BUDGET

Taking the time to calculate monthly expenses and income for home and mosad accounts, and putting those numbers on paper, is crucial to financial success. It is impossible to reach your goals if you don't know what they are. Training for and running a 26-mile marathon is done very differently than for a 40-yard dash. Preparing for the wrong one is inefficient, a let-down, and a waste of good time and energy.



6 TAKE CARE OF YOUR PHYSICAL AND SPIRITUAL HEALTH

The fact is that if you maintain irregular and unhealthy sleep and eating habits, you will not be functioning at your optimum. Schedule your days and nights so you can be as productive as possible. I reassessed my phone usage and now try my best to keep it out of sight when I come home in the evening. I blocked various social media apps, games, and news sites that wasted my time and were either spiritually or emotionally draining.

Now, instead of constantly following the “success stories” of other shluchim I was able to maintain a positive attitude and clear mind for my own family and shlichus.

As my financial stress faded, I was also able to reinstate shiurim and learning schedules that in the past I had deemed impossible. A focused mindset helped me realize that I really could make the time for these important, spiritual goals. Of course, don't overwhelm yourself. Make sure to start with small, doable steps that will work for you. When it comes to these areas, I set my goals in a similar fashion as I would with someone just starting their journey towards Yiddishkeit: slow and steady.

פעולות מול חובות

פשיטא – שכל פעולה בנוגע ליר"ש ותומ"צ וכו' טובה ונחוצה היא, אלא, ככתבי מאז **לא יכנסו לחובות**, וכבר הי' מעשה אצל אחרים וכו' און מהג'ט זיך, ל"ע גוט אָפּגעברייט ויצא שכרם כו', וד"ל.
(ממכתב ד' ניסן תשל"ב (אג"ק חכ"ז ע' שעג)

PEULOS VS. DEBT

Of course, any activity relating to yiras Shamayim, Torah and mitzvos, etc., is both positive and important. However, as I have already written, do not run into debt. Such an episode occurred with others. Unfortunately, they got into big trouble and lost more than they gained.

Letter dated 4 Nissan, 5732 (*Igros Kodesh*, vol. 27, p. 373)

מבצעים עם חשבון

[מהעתקת המזכיר, על גליון השאלה, אודות עבודת המבצעים (בשנים 1974-1975) שעלו \$70,000, בלי התחשבות עם המצב הכספי:]

הזכרתיו עה"צ.
ואשרי חלקו וכו' – אבל בכ"ז – צ"ל בחשבון וכו', עכ"פ מכאן ולהבא. וק"ל.
להקל בהעבר ולהשתתף בזכות הגדול – מענק חד פעמי – ז' אלף שקל.
ממענה חורף תשל"ו (אג"ק חל"א ע' עו)

MIVTZOYIM WITH A CHESHBON

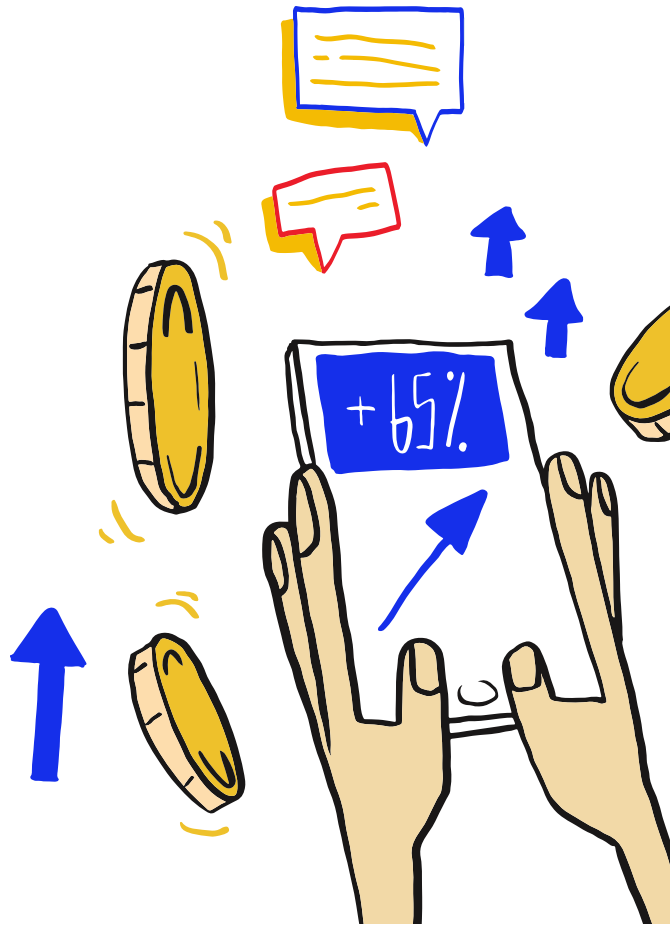
[One of the mazkirim wrote to the Rebbe that in the years 1974-1975, \$70,000 was spent on mivtzoym, despite financial constraints. The Rebbe replied with the following maaneh:]

I mentioned you at the Ohel.

You are fortunate to have accomplished this. However, at the same time, you must operate in a deliberate manner, etc., at least from now on.

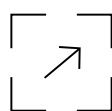
To alleviate the past financial state and to participate in the great zechus, I am giving you \$7,000 as a one-time grant.

Maaneh written in the winter of 5736 (*Igros Kodesh*, vol. 31, p. 76)



I don't submit that I have things perfectly sorted out; I still struggle. Every day brings its own set of challenges. But if I was able to get to where I am today, I am sure many of you can, as well. By redefining my outlook, reaching out for support, and good old budgeting and hard work, I am proud to say that I am, boruch Hashem, pretty much debt-free. Rather than my money matters bringing on fear and chaos, I can face challenges with clarity and I know how to move forward. I can make confident decisions because I have a strong support system that sets me up for success. Instead of grasping at straws, I can face the reality of managing my personal and shlichus finances with confidence.

Rabbi Teldon currently spends more time actively pursuing his shlichus, and much less time dealing with money issues. He encourages everyone to see how much more they can accomplish in their shlichus by being financially organized and goal-oriented. He can be reached at shlichusclarity@gmail.com.



MONEY QUIZ



Scored between 15-30? Call a close friend now and say, "Hey, I think I need some help getting my stuff in order. You have a few minutes?"

Scored between 31-40? Not bad. Choose one or two areas to focus on so you keep on improving.

Scored above 41? You have what to teach. Put the word out there that you can be helpful. Friends will find you.

HOW WELL DO YOU KNOW WHERE YOU'RE AT?

TALLY YOUR SCORE ON THE QUIZ BELOW
ACCORDING TO THE FOLLOWING POINT SYSTEM:

I HAVE NO CLUE.

1 POINT

I HAVE A BASIC IDEA.

2 POINTS

I'M CLEAR, CONFIDENT, AND COMFORTABLE WITH MY ANSWER. **3 POINTS**

1. If you'd receive an \$18,000 donation today, where would the money go?
2. How many of your donors give you more than \$1,800 per year?
3. How much money do you spend on overdraft fees and bounced checks per year?
4. How much money do you need over the next 10 days?
5. How many fundraising meetings do you have scheduled over the next two weeks?
6. Which app on your phone do you waste the most time on?
7. How many WhatsApp groups can you leave without repercussion?
8. How many hours of sleep do you get on an average night?
9. Which parts of your shlichus do you do best?
10. Which parts of your shlichus are the most emotionally draining?
11. How are you planning to pay for your children's simchos?
12. Do you become stressed when asked about your financial books?
13. How much is your total salary?
14. How much is your total debt?
15. With which friend can you speak heart-to-heart about anything? 🗨️